

Session II: Naya Nuki — Due October 12

1. Read chapters 1-3 in [Nayak Nuki: Girl Who Ran by Kenneth Th omasma](#) — *Parent Note: If you don't want to read this book out loud to your younger children, feel free to simply read them the summary below so they know what's happening in the story. I think this story should be appropriate for K-6, but every parent and child is different. Please do what is best for your family.*
2. Read the following: [Shoshone](#) by Barbara A. Gray-Kanatiosh — pages 4-5 (Where they lived) and 10-11 (Homes).
3. Read the biography below: Kenneth Th omasma: the Storyteller Who Brought History to Life
4. Complete the Make a Shoshone Survival Kit homework

Naya Nuki Chapters 1-3 Summary

Naya Nuki is a young Shoshone girl who lives with her family and friends near the mountains and rivers of what is now Idaho and Montana. The Shoshone people are very good at living off the land. They hunt animals, gather berries and roots, and move their camp with the seasons. Naya Nuki loves her people and her best friend, a girl named Sacajawea. Together they play, work, and grow up learning the ways of their tribe.

One terrible day, a group of warriors from another tribe called the Minnetaree come and raid the Shoshone camp. It happens very fast and it is very scary. Some of the Shoshone people are captured and taken away from their homes and families, including Naya Nuki and Sacajawea. They are marched far, far away from everything they know. Naya Nuki is frightened, but she is also very brave inside.

Even though Naya Nuki is a prisoner in a strange place, she never stops thinking about her family and her home. She watches everything around her very carefully — which way the rivers flow, where the sun rises, how the land looks. Deep in her heart, she makes up her mind about something very important: she is going to find her way back home, no matter how long it takes or how hard it is.

Kenneth Th omasma: The Storyteller Who Brought History to Life

Kenneth Th omasma was a teacher, author, and master storyteller. He was born on September 2, 1930, in Grand Rapids, Michigan. When Ken was a young boy, he worked alongside his father picking tomatoes during the Great Depression. He also discovered a love of books when he learned he could borrow them from the public library. A librarian encouraged him to write a

book someday, and Ken never forgot her words. After serving in the United States Navy, he went to college and became an elementary school teacher in Grand Rapids, Michigan.

Ken eventually moved with his wife, Bobby, to Jackson, Wyoming, where they worked together at Kelly Elementary School. The small school needed a great deal of help, and Ken was determined to make it a wonderful place for children. He worked to improve the school grounds, raised money for supplies and repairs, and even built an ice-skating rink for the students each winter. Over the years, he helped create 32 ice rinks! Ken believed that every child deserved a good education and personal attention from a caring teacher. He looked for problems that needed solving and then rolled up his sleeves to help. His love of teaching would eventually lead him to discover another way to reach children: through books and storytelling.

Ken fell in love with the story of Sacajawea while working at a children's summer camp in Montana during the 1960s. Sacajawea was a Shoshoni woman who helped guide the Lewis and Clark expedition across the American West in 1805. Ken admired her courage, resourcefulness, and ability to overcome difficult challenges. He wanted children to learn about her and other Native American people, so he began writing books about Native American children facing exciting and sometimes dangerous adventures. His first book, *Naya Nuki: Shoshoni Girl Who Ran*, was published in 1983. It told the story of a young Shoshoni girl who escaped after being captured by enemies. Ken went on to write 11 books, including *The Truth About Sacajawea*. His stories combined historical research with imaginative adventures to help young readers learn about the past.

Ken was especially gifted at making his stories feel real. His friend Peter Ward called him a master storyteller because he knew how to capture the feelings of his characters and draw children into their adventures. Ken believed that feelings were the heart of every powerful story. He wanted readers to feel the characters' fear, courage, sadness, and excitement as they faced challenges and made difficult choices. When writing a book, he sometimes read each chapter aloud to his own students and listened to their ideas about the story and its title. He also traveled to schools and museums, often dressed in traditional-style buckskins, to read his books aloud and answer children's questions. Students enjoyed listening because he told stories as though the events were happening right in front of them. Ken also worked hard to make his stories historically accurate, so children could enjoy an adventure while learning about real people and cultures.

Ken's love of storytelling also inspired him to help honor Sacajawea in a special way. In the late 1990s, he led a campaign to place her image on the United States dollar coin. He even biked along the route of the Lewis and Clark expedition at age 70, stopping at schools, newspapers, motels, and cafes to tell people why Sacajawea deserved recognition. His efforts helped bring about the new dollar coin featuring Sacajawea and her baby, which was released in 2000.

Ken continued sharing his love of books, history, and learning well into his 80s. He died in Jackson on November 14, 2023, at the age of 93. Although he is remembered for his books and his work honoring Sacajawea, he was also a devoted husband, father, and teacher who cared deeply about children. His life reminds us that a good storyteller does more than entertain:

stories can help us understand other people, discover history, find courage, and imagine what we might accomplish ourselves.

Make a Shoshone Survival Kit Homework

Your challenge this week: Imagine you are a young Shoshone person living in the world of Naya Nuki (1801, Eastern Idaho and western Montana). What useful items would you need to travel, find food, stay warm, or navigate the wilderness?

Each student should make a small kit using a shoebox, pouch, basket, or decorated cardboard box. Fill it with handmade miniature objects, drawings, or safely collected natural materials. Bring it to class to share.

What you might include:

- A miniature food pouch with dried grass or paper representations of food.
- A small bundle of pretend firewood made from twigs. (Or buffalo chips.)
- A miniature blanket or robe made from fabric scraps.
- A model of a tool or hunting implement made from clay or cardboard.
- A small first-aid or emergency supply bundle for their imagined journey. (Herbs?)

How much should you pack in your kit?

- Grades K–2: Include three to four items.
- Grades 3–6: Include five to seven items and write a sentence explaining the purpose of each.